

STIFF OPPOSITION
Both RSS affiliates and Left activists oppose the introduction of GM crops

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GM MUSTARD/ BJP VS RSS

SEED OF CONFLICT

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

The Bharatiya Janata Party-led Union government's ambitious plan for the commercial launch of indigenously-developed genetically modified (GM) mustard—seen as a key step towards achieving self-sufficiency in oilseeds production—is facing stiff opposition. Ironically, among those opposing the move are leaders of the BJP's ideological fountainhead Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) and its affiliates. In the first week of November, a top RSS leader is learnt to have approached Prime Minister Narendra Modi's office to convey the reservations of the Sangh and its affiliates. Following this, the Bharatiya Kisan Sangh (BKS) and Swadeshi Jagran Manch (SJM) wrote to the prime minister, seeking his intervention to stall the move. While the BKS is an RSS affiliate among farmers, the SJM is the Sangh's economic think-tank.

Amid all this, the Supreme Court on November 4—acting on a petition moved by food safety activists—directed the Union government to put on record the data and expert findings on the basis of which the decision to release the GM seed variety—known as Dhara Mustard Hybrid-11 (DMH-11)—was taken. Additional solicitor general Aishwarya Bhati has assured the apex court bench of Justices Dinesh Maheshwari and Sudhanshu Dhulia that the government will not take any "precipitate action" till the matter is decided.

According to the World Health Organization, GM foods are derived from organisms whose genetic material (DNA) has been modified in a way that does not occur naturally. Most GM crops lay claim to improving yield through resistance to plant diseases or increased tolerance to herbicides.